
TRANSITIONS LAB · FIELD METHOD

Ethics & Consent in the Field

How to do primary research with people, in real contexts, without harming the people it depends on. The Lab's working standard, set out plainly.

A practical guide for anyone gathering field evidence: informed consent, data protection, power, and the duty of care that rigorous research requires.

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FIELD METHOD

Rigour includes the people you study

Good fieldwork is not only accurate. It is fair to the people who give it their time and their answers. Ethics is not a compliance form filed before the real work begins. It is part of the method, and it shapes the quality of the evidence.

Research that treats respondents as data sources to be extracted from produces worse evidence, not just a worse relationship. People who do not trust the interviewer, or do not understand what they are agreeing to, give guarded or performative answers. The ethical standard and the evidential standard point the same way: treat people with respect, be honest about what you are doing, and the data improves.

4

principles that anchor the standard

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rule: consent is ongoing, not a signature

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findings worth harm to a participant

THE FOUNDATION

Four principles

Field ethics rests on four principles drawn from the established research-ethics tradition. They are simple to state and demanding to practise.

Respect for persons.

People are participants, not subjects. They decide whether to take part, on the basis of a clear understanding of what participation involves, and they may stop at any time without penalty.

Beneficence.

The research should aim at good and, at minimum, do no harm. Foreseeable risks to participants are identified and minimised before fieldwork begins.

Justice.

The benefits and burdens of research are shared fairly. The people who bear the burden of being studied should not be excluded from its benefits, and the most vulnerable are not the most researched.

Respect for community.

In the field, the individual sits within a community. Research engages local structures with respect, and does not damage the relationships people rely on after the researchers leave.

The ethical standard and the evidential standard point the same way. Treat people with respect, and the evidence improves.

ETHICS IN THE FIELD

THE CORE PRACTICE

Informed consent, properly done

Consent is the practical heart of research ethics, and it is routinely reduced to a signature on a form nobody read. Done properly, it is a short, honest conversation that a participant genuinely understands.

Informed consent has four components, each of which can fail quietly:

- › Information. The participant understands who you are, what the research is for, what taking part involves, how long it takes, and what happens to their answers.
- › Comprehension. The information is given in the participant's language, in plain terms, at a literacy level that fits. Comprehension is checked, not assumed.
- › Voluntariness. The choice is free of coercion or undue inducement. Payment compensates time; it does not buy consent to something a person would otherwise refuse.
- › Ongoing. Consent can be withdrawn at any point, including after the interview. It is a state, not a one-time signature.

KEY POINT**The plain-language test**

If a participant cannot explain back to you, in their own words, what the research is for and what will happen to their answers, they have not given informed consent, whatever the form says. The burden is on the researcher to be understood, not on the participant to understand.

THE HARD PART

Power, vulnerability, and context

Most ethical failures in field research are not malice. They are the result of a power difference the researcher did not notice, because it did not affect them.

Power is always present

An outside researcher, often better resourced and connected, carries authority a participant may feel unable to refuse. People may say yes because saying no feels risky, or give the answer they think is wanted. Naming and lowering that gradient is the researcher's job.

Vulnerability is contextual

A participant may be vulnerable through poverty, insecurity, age, gender, disability, or legal status. Vulnerability is not a fixed category; it depends on the topic and the setting. The same question is safe for one person and risky for another.

Three practices lower the risk:

- › Interview where the participant is safe and comfortable, not where it is convenient for the researcher. Privacy is part of safety.
- › Anticipate distress. Some questions reopen hard experiences. Know when to pause, when to stop, and where to point someone for support if a topic surfaces something serious.
- › Do not extract and vanish. Where possible, findings return to the community that produced them, in a form they can use.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW

Data protection and the duty of care

The duty to a participant does not end when the interview does. The data they gave can still harm them if it is carelessly handled, and protecting it is an ethical obligation, not only a legal one.

Stage	The standard
Collection	Gather only what the research genuinely needs. Data you do not collect cannot leak.
Identifiers	Separate identifying information from responses; store it separately, or remove it as early as possible.
Storage	Encrypt and access-control personal data. A spreadsheet of named responses on an open laptop is a breach waiting to happen.
Sharing	Report in aggregate or with genuine anonymity. Check that no individual is identifiable by combination, a small group plus a location can identify a person.
Retention	Keep personal data only as long as needed, then delete it. Indefinite retention is indefinite risk.

Where a legal framework applies, the GDPR in Europe, national data-protection law elsewhere, it sets a floor, not a ceiling. The ethical standard is often higher than the legal minimum, particularly where participants are outside the jurisdiction whose law protects them.

HOW THE LAB WORKS

The standard in practice

The Lab treats ethics as inseparable from method. Consent is recorded and genuine, data is protected by design, local researchers who know the context lead the fieldwork, and findings return to the communities that produced them wherever possible. This is not an overhead on the research; it is part of what makes the evidence trustworthy.

- › For a specific study, this standard becomes a written ethics and data-management protocol, matched to the context, the topic, and the applicable law.

WORKING WITH TRANSITIONS LAB

From standard to protocol

This guide sets out the Lab's working standard for ethical fieldwork. A live study turns that standard into a protocol built for your context.

IN THIS FREE RESOURCE	IN AN ENGAGEMENT, WE GO FURTHER
The four principles and the consent components.	› A written consent process in the right languages, with comprehension checks designed for the setting.
The power and vulnerability practices.	› A context-specific risk assessment, and researchers who know the community and its sensitivities.
The data-protection standard, in general.	› A data-management plan compliant with the applicable law, from collection to deletion.
The duty of care, as a principle.	› Findings returned to participants, and a genuine anonymity review before anything is published.

The standard here is what good fieldwork requires of anyone; an engagement is where it is built into a study designed for your people and place.

If a decision in your work turns on evidence of what a technology or programme actually does to real people, we are glad to talk it through, with no obligation. transitionslab.org

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